



Video on Wikipedia

Wikipedia is all set to offer video as a part of the content on the encyclopedia pages, using partners such as Archive.org and Metavid



Beware of Trolls

Trolls on Wikipedia are likely to be most active when a particular subject, place or personality is in the news. So be careful of what you read then, and always check the edit history

Feature

administrative responsibility over the Sysops and other editors. They can for example, ban IP ranges, protect pages, block vandals and the like. Sysops can also do some of these things, but to a lesser degree. Bureaucrats manage, appoint and handle bots, which are scripts that automatically tweak, correct or change content on Wikipedia. Above the bureaucrats is the Arbitration Committee, known as the Arbcom. The Arbcom handles and settles disputes, and takes policy decisions about the project. The Sysops, bureaucrats and the members of the Arbcom are all democratically elected from the levels below. Sometimes, bureaucrats can appoint other bureaucrats when necessary. There is a pyramid structure to the organisation, with around 15,000 Sysops, around 30 bureaucrats and 15 people in the Arbcom.

Above the Arbcom are the stewards. These are very rare, are involved more actively in the sister projects of Wikipedia, simply because the lower levels can operate Wikipedia efficiently. The stewards are also voted, and are called in when very important decisions have to be taken or disputes within the Arbcom have to be settled. These are high level policy decisions and the like. Above the stewards are the Founders, Jimmy Wales is one of these, but he is also a steward.

All of this might not affect the readers of Wikipedia, but drastically affect the editors. There is an inherent bureaucracy in the functioning of Wikipedia, and new editors might not be able to exploit the system as well as the old ones. Many editors tend to think of pages they have started as their pet projects, and follow it closely across the edits. There may be people with a different point of view who boldly change the content, as one of the policies encourages them to. This results in edit wars, and editors may revert pages to their original states, known as revert wars. There is a three time revert rule, after which the page is automatically locked, and requires higher authority to clear things up. Ideally, Wikipedia ensures that the articles have vastly different points of view, and cover the subject completely. However, practically, this is not true. A huge chunk of the content on the English language Wikipedia is biased towards America, and has content geared towards American users, and "reads" as if an American is reading it. Also, the content that is created about remote locations, little-known people and subjects, are almost always biased in some way or another, and often not accurate or comprehensive. The best way to find out how thorough an article is, is to check the number of edits using the history tab on any page. The rule of the thumb is that the greater the number of edits, the greater the accuracy of the article.

Vandals and Sock Puppets

There are vandals that sometimes get loose on Wikipedia. These are sometimes drastic, and deface a public personality, or the page of a corporation. The PR personnel of small and large organisations often edit the pages that they are interested in, in a way that benefits them. For large, multinational companies, a bias is not possible, but for smaller companies, slyly putting in a critical line about competition, or making bold claims without references or proof, is not difficult. Other kinds of vandals spread misinformation, most of which is hidden in a line somewhere and not easily detectable, even by experts on that subject. This can include propagation of myths, rumours and debatable information.

Another breed of editors is not above using multiple accounts to edit the same page, or keep a watch on content. This may be to influence voting, or to make it appear as if the majority of editors have a particular consensus about an article. Official policy requires all editors with alternate accounts



to declare these accounts by linking to them from their user page, but this is not often done. Such accounts are known as "sock puppets", "socks" for short, and the activity known as "socking".

If you care to follow Wikipedia editors and users on IRC (#wikipedia on irc.freenode.net), it becomes easy to follow some of the problems that Wikipedia editors and users face. Most of the chat is about certain articles, cleaning up portals, requests by editors for Sysop action and the like. Now and then, however, a new editor faces certain problems, and the shortcomings of Wikipedia become apparent. Reporting sock accounts for example, even after they are identified, is a long process, and the sock can do considerable damage before they are officially banned. There is a certain amount of red tape, and a procedural slowness for

taking actions, which may be in place for the security of Wikipedia, but at the same time serves to slow down improvements of the encyclopaedia. The bureaucracy is often resented, and most editors don't even take the trouble to follow the procedures required to safeguard even their pet project, often requiring more effort than casual editors are willing to make.

Ribbons, barnstars and service awards

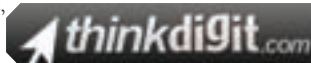
Wikipedia has a number of devices for appreciating the efforts of individual editors. Even if they are not promoted to Sysop status or beyond, other editors can put up barnstars to acknowledge the user's contributions. Service awards are given to editors who dedicatedly reach a certain edit count, over a specific span of time. Ribbons are used to display barnstars or service awards in as little space as possible, so as not to clutter a particular user page.

There are eleven levels of editorial contribution service awards. From the lowest to the highest, these are Burba, Novato, three Grogard levels, and five Tutnum levels. When a particular number of edits are reached in the stipulated time period, editors can add the relevant badges, books or ribbons to their user pages. The books range from The First Book of Wikipedia for Novices, or Burbas, to the Book of All Knowledge for the highest level Tatnum. The editors on these levels can alternatively place service badges on their user profiles, the Tatnum levels have metal stars for each of the levels. These are iron, bronze, silver, gold, platinum and plutonium.

Wikilove and Wikiquote

Despite all shortcomings, Wikipedia is still the most visited reference source on the internet. Browsing a few pages every now and then does not give a true idea of the size and scope of the project. It is one of the biggest success stories of web 2.0, and the project is truly a political statement that people living in the last half of the twentieth century thought could never be made.

The project is non-commercial, with a creative commons licence, and is considered by many as proof that human beings can create something for free that is better than commercial counterparts. The fact that Wikipedia put Encarta out of business vindicates this feeling, and Wikipedia editors have been generally functioning with good cheer and a strong communal feeling. It is still growing at a rapid rate, and there is a lot of ground left to cover.



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